

STROLL IN THE PARK
A Ranthambore tiger on the move

Photographs courtesy: TIGER WATCH

ENVIRONMENT
RANTHAMBORE

THE MISSING STRIPES

Behind the missing 15 big cats in the Ranthambore National Park are a lax monitoring system by local forest officials, political pressure and unreliable numbers

By Rohit Parihar

The initial news came as a shock—a report by the Rajasthan forest department dated October 14 stated that 25 tigers in the famous Ranthambore National Park and Tiger Reserve were "missing". While 11 animals were untraced for over a year, evidence of 14 others had not been obtained for months. According to the official census, the total number of tigers in Ranthambore was 52 in 2022. The worst fear: was Ranthambore going to suffer the fate of the Sariska wildlife sanctuary, also in Rajasthan, where the local tiger population was wiped out in 2006? However, better news followed on November 6—forest officials found evidence of 10 of the 25 big cats. Two probes have been ordered. On November 4, Rajasthan's principal chief conservator of forests (PCCF) and chief wildlife warden Pavan Kumar Upadhyay ordered an inquiry into the disappearing